



RUNNERS participate during the Baker to Vegas relay through the Mojave Desert. Trevor Kirk's supporters urged runners to boycott the race as a show of solidarity with the deputy they said was wrongfully prosecuted.

WILLIAM LIANG For The Times

Law enforcement discord steals spotlight at footrace

He was somewhere near Baker, well out into the Southern California desert, when the scrum of cherry lights appeared ahead.

It was the sure sign of police cars — a seemingly improbable number for this lonely stretch of windswept road. But behind the wheel of his rented sedan, Sean Kennedy smiled.

He'd found what he was looking for: the relay race.

For Los Angeles law enforcement, the Baker to Vegas footrace is the premiere sporting

This year's Baker to Vegas relay, far from fostering camaraderie, was riven by tensions in L.A. County Sheriff's Department

By Keri Blakinger
REPORTING FROM BAKER, CALIF.

event of the year — a sort of Super Bowl for the “thin blue line” crowd. Police departments and sheriff's stations spend months raising the thousands of dollars it takes to send each 20-runner team to the dusty start just north of Baker and on to the glittering finish by the Las Vegas Strip 120 miles later.

The Los Angeles County Sheriff's Department usually sends a couple of dozen teams, some of which are regulars on the winner's podium. And even

[See Footrace, A7]

Trans rights will be a key issue in governor's race

President Trump's efforts to undermine California's liberal values will be at 2026 campaign's forefront.

By LAURA J. NELSON

PALM SPRINGS — In a ballroom packed with more than 1,000 people raising money for LGBTQ+ youths, veteran California legislative leader Toni Atkins didn't mince words: To be a gay or transgender teenager right now, she said, must feel like “a rug has been pulled from beneath your feet.”

In her fiery speech at the annual Harvey Milk Diversity Breakfast, Atkins, who is running for California governor, said President Trump and other Republicans are working to “legislate our trans siblings out of public life.”

“These aren't just political stunts: These are acts that put lives in danger and strip away basic human dignity,” Atkins said. “So hear me, as I say: Trans people belong. Trans youth deserve love, joy and our protection.”

Atkins' speech, which drew rousing applause, offered a glimpse of how Trump's efforts to undermine California's liberal values — including support for transgender Americans — will be at the heart of the state's 2026 campaign for governor.

In his first 100 days, Trump issued executive or-

ders banning trans women from women's sports and barring the federal government from recognizing genders other than male or female.

Trump is also pushing to ban transgender Americans from the U.S. military, writing in an executive order that transgender identity is a “falsehood” inconsistent with the “humility and selflessness required of a service member.” The Supreme Court cleared the way last week for that ban to take effect.

“Cruelty, and an attempt to humiliate, seems to be the point of what they are doing,” [See Governor, A6]

Bass' goal for hiring at LAPD proves elusive

Amid a budget crisis, the city considers cutting the number of officers in order to save civilian jobs.

By DAVID ZAHNISER

Two years ago, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass laid out an ambitious and expensive goal for her first city budget: restore the size of the Los Angeles Police Department to 9,500 officers.

At the time, the LAPD was struggling with recruitment, and Bass — just four months into her job — openly worried the department would soon fall below 9,000.

Now, the mayor's hiring goal looks even more out of reach. With the city battered by a budget crisis and homicides falling by double digits, some are wondering: Just how low can, or should, LAPD staffing go?

On Thursday, the City Council's budget committee provided a short-term answer, moving forward with a plan to cut the LAPD by an additional 300 officers — not through layoffs but simply by slowing down recruitment. Such a move would leave the department with 8,400 officers by June 2026, down from about 8,700 this year and 10,000 five years ago.

The slowdown, if approved by the City Council later this month, would free up \$9.5 million, helping the city save some of the civilian

[See LAPD, A6]

Altadena firms on their own for cleanup

Four months after an inferno ripped through Altadena, a time capsule of rubble and the shells of gutted shops and restaurants still lines the business district of North Lake Avenue. Near the top of the street, Maggie Cortez's beloved Mexican eatery stands — one of the town's few survivors.

She and others fear that the area could remain a wasteland while residential parts of Altadena move forward with rebuilding.

The Federal Emergency Management Agency tasked the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers to clean up debris at private residences, some public buildings and places of worship — but not commercial properties.

“Commercial property debris removal is the responsibility of the property owner. Currently, USACE has no task from FEMA to execute commercial property removal,” the Army Corps said in a statement.

ECC Constructors was awarded a contract for more than \$668 million to do the

The Army Corps was told to deal with residences in the fire zones, but not the commercial properties

By Colleen Shalby



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

MAGGIE Cortez, center, who owns El Patron restaurant, is fighting for its survival after the Eaton fire destroyed nearby businesses and neighborhoods.

residential cleanup in areas affected by the Eaton fire, records show. So while those lots are being cleared with speed, most commercial property owners have been left to clear their land. And many are questioning whether they can afford to when the business outlook is so bleak, leaving swaths of the unincorporated town stuck in a toxic limbo.

Inside El Patron, music plays overhead as customers are transported to normalcy. But reminders of what happened in January aren't far away — across the street are the remains of a pizza place and a historic church, while caution tape still clings to the trees at the neighboring park.

Cortez, 45, said customers — her “family,” whose photos adorn the walls — visit on their way to check in on their destroyed homes or to oversee remediation. But after an initial surge, business has waned. She fears for her restaurant's survival.

Cortez lives two blocks away and knows the sight is

[See Cleanup, A10]

Pope's heritage highlights a complex history

Leo XIV's Creole roots raise awareness of identity and racism in U.S.

By JACK BROOK AND DEEPA BHARATH

NEW ORLEANS — The new pope's French-sounding last name, Prevost, intrigued Jari Honora, a New Orleans genealogist, who began digging in the archives and discovered the pope had deep roots in the

Big Easy.

All four of Pope Leo XIV's maternal great-grandparents were “free people of color” in Louisiana, based on 19th century census records, Honora found. As part of the melting pot of French, Spanish, African and Native American cultures in Louisiana, the pope's maternal ancestors would be considered

Creole.

“It was special for me because I share that heritage and so do many of my friends who are Catholic here in New Orleans,” said Honora, a historian at the Historic New Orleans Collection, a museum in the French Quarter.

Honora and others in the Black and Creole Catholic communities say the elec-

tion of Leo — a Chicago native who spent more than two decades in Peru, including eight years as a bishop — is just what the Roman Catholic Church needs to unify the global church and elevate the profile of Black Catholics, whose history and contributions have long been overlooked.

[See Pope, A4]

Last living U.S. hostage to be freed

Hamas says it will release Edan Alexander in hopes of securing a lasting ceasefire in Gaza. **WORLD, A3**

Tennessee aids ICE in arrests

Nashville's immigrant community worries after joint operation detains 103. **NATION, A5**

Weather Cooler.

L.A. Basin: 72/54. **B5**

Few charged in campus protests

Anger flares anew at how authorities handled cases at USC and UCLA. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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